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Sutton data center not a surprise for all

Idea of building midsize plant was discussed publicly more than a year ago

By Aaron Pressman
GLOBE STAFF
and Yogev Toby
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Residents of Sutton expressed shock and outrage this week when they learned one of Robert Kraft's companies had proposed building a massive data center complex in their small town 10 miles south of Worcester.

But the idea was first discussed in public over a year ago when Sutton's Select Board was encouraging a packaging company owned by the Kraft Group to develop a large parcel of land it owns on the north side of town, according to videos of public town Select Board meetings reviewed by the Globe.

It's not clear when the Krafts took up the idea, which was discussed Tuesday at a Select Board meeting. In December, a Kraft representative at a Select Board meeting said they had not formally presented any plan to Sutton officials.

But there's no doubt its $16 billion data center plan — potentially one of the largest in the country — has crashed headlong into the powerful political backlash nationwide against the energy-hungry facilities used to develop and run artificial intelligence systems.

►At Select Board meeting, harsh words for data center plan. D1.

The Kraft Group did not respond Wednesday to requests for comment.

The 383-acre parcel has been used for industrial purposes since the 1930s, according to town filings with the Worcester County Register of Deeds. Before the Krafts owned it, it housed a cement factory and a gravel pit.

In 2022, Sutton had given the Kraft company, Unified Global Packaging Group, a tax incentive deal to build a huge warehouse on part of a 383-acre parcel it bought for $9.5 million in 2020. But by 2025, Uni-

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THE DREAM OF FLIGHT — OR A NIGHTMARE?



Long battle over CEO's private airstrip divides Vermont town



PHOTOS BY CALEB KENNA FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Top: An aerial view of Kyle Clark's property in Lincoln, Vt., where he wants to use a private airstrip. But neighbors, including Sarah Laird and Dan Guy (above), have been fighting him for years.

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE STAFF

LINCOLN, Vt. — The aging interlopers were worried about getting arrested.

They were hiking up a steep, rutted, public road through a 130-acre estate to the site of a proposed airstrip they had fought for years. The owners had recently issued no-trespass orders to 23 neighbors, including them.

"I'm gonna stay on the road because I was warned," said Dan Guy, a 72-year-old retired carpenter, peering over a stone wall at the 900-foot grass landing strip that has deeply divided neighbors in this rural Vermont town.

They were soon confronted by two men who followed them down the road and told the group surveillance cameras had caught them on the property. The men refused to identify themselves but were well known to Guy: caretakers for the owners, Kyle Clark, chief executive of one of Vermont's most successful startups, electric plane manufacturer Beta Technologies, and his wife, Katie.

"We're going to get photos of the cars that are here," said one, sporting a backward hat in camo with the Beta logo on it, as he rushed past the neighbors.

AIRSTRIP, Page A10

Witness in Farwell case urges changes

Doctor sees 'opportunity' to set protocol for cases with ties to police officers

By Laura Crimaldi and Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

A medical expert for federal prosecutors in the Sandra Birchmore case urged state law enforcement officials on Wednesday to rethink how they investigate strangulation deaths, amid lingering questions over how Massachusetts authorities concluded Birchmore hanged herself.

Dr. Bill Smock, an emergency medicine physician who has worked for the medical examiner and law enforcement agencies in Kentucky, called for better training to detect possible strangulation or suffocation in unattended deaths. He further pressed for a specific protocol for approaching suspicious deaths in cases in which the victims were in an intimate relationship with a law enforcement officer. He likened such a new protocol to how special investigations are conducted in police shootings.

"This is an opportunity for Massachusetts to say, 'We had some issues with Sandra's investigation. Let's make sure that the mistakes that occurred here don't happen again,' " Smock said in a phone interview.

"Sandra's case would be an example where clearly the investigating agency knew there was a connection to a police officer or multiple police of-

FARWELL, Page A7

Democrats vow to do two things at once

Say their investigations will lead to lower prices

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — In the giddy days since midterm voters swept them into power, congressional Democrats have vowed to address not only the high cost of living that fueled their victories but the corruption they say is rampant in the Trump administration.

"Walk and chew gum at the same time" — that's the mantra from lawmakers who assert they can both legislate and investigate effectively.

But they also are trying to link accountability and affordability, arguing that oversight of the executive branch will help reverse the price increases on gas, groceries, and other essentials that angered so many voters.

"We didn't treat corruption as some abstract complaint about ethics in Washington," said Senator Chuck Schumer, the New York Democrat in line to lead the new majority next year. "We told people the plain truth: that your costs are high in no small part because the powerful in this town are too busy helping themselves at your expense."

The House and Senate are empowered to make

DEMOCRATS, Page A6



Drops in

Thursday: Cloudy, rainy. High: 52-57. Low: 38-43.
Friday: Cooler, rainy. High: 41-46. Low: 37-42.
Sunrise: 6:31 Sunset: 4:25
Comics and Weather, **D5-6.**
Obituaries, **C8-9.**

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Nurses in deal

Brigham and Women's Hospital and its nurses union reached an agreement a few hours before a planned strike this morning. **B1.**

The White House warned Democrats that aggressive oversight of the Trump administration "may cross the line into blatant criminality." **A2.**

Legally admitted as refugees, they fear deportation

Uncertainty rises as Trump policies change

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio
GLOBE STAFF

Lida, a young woman from Afghanistan, was evacuated by the US military after the Taliban takeover in 2021. Her US-funded job in education put her life at risk. (The Globe is identifying her by a pseudonym used in court documents.)

After enduring an arduous screening process while she waited in Qatar, she entered the United States as a refugee in early 2024. Safe at last, she could begin rebuilding her life.

Or so she thought. Last year, the Trump administration began re-vetting refugees admitted under the Biden administration and paused the processing of their green card applications. Last month, officials tightened the vise further, announcing that refugees notified of a revocation of status would have just 10 days to contest the decision.

Now, like thousands of other refugees, Lida is terrified of being sent back to Afghanistan, where she fears she and her family could be killed by the Taliban. In the meantime, her life here has ground to a halt; she had to put aside her plan to attend college this year

REFUGEES, Page A6



SANAULLAH SEIAM/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

Afghan women and children in Kandahar province last month. Refugees in the US from Afghanistan say they'd be in danger if they were sent back.